PASTRY & ENRICHED DOUGHS · SWEET

Babkallah

Chocolate-cinnamon babka, rolled into three logs and braided like challah.

MAKES **1 LOAF / 12 SERVINGS** · ACTIVE **1 HR**
TOTAL **ABOUT 5 HR**
PAN **RIMMED BAKING SHEET** · OVEN **350F (175C)**

BEFORE YOU START

- Butter for the dough at room temperature
- Instant-read thermometer for the milk
- Line a rimmed baking sheet with parchment

INGREDIENTS

Dough

113 g	1/2 cup	Whole milk
7 g	2 1/4 tsp	Active dry yeast 1 envelope
66 g	1/3 cup	Granulated sugar
70 g	4	Large egg yolks
	1 tsp	Vanilla extract
390 g	3 cups	All-purpose flour plus more for kneading
3 g	1 tsp	Diamond Crystal kosher salt
113 g	1 stick	Unsalted butter in 1/2-inch pieces, room temperature, plus more for the bowl

Filling & assembly

170 g	6 oz	Semisweet chocolate finely chopped, about 1 cup
65 g	1/3 cup	Light brown sugar packed
	1 1/2 tsp	Ground cinnamon
	Pinch	Kosher salt
57 g	4 Tbsp	Unsalted butter melted and cooled
	1	Large egg beaten
		Demerara sugar for sprinkling

METHOD

Dough

1. Warm the milk over low heat, swirling, just until lukewarm, about **105F (40C)**. The microwave works too; just don't overshoot, since hot milk kills yeast. Pour into a large bowl and whisk in the yeast.
   WAIT **5 TO 10 MIN**
   ✓ *Foamy*

2. Whisk in the granulated sugar, yolks and vanilla. Add the flour, salt and butter pieces and stir with a wooden spoon into a shaggy dough. Knead on a lightly floured surface **8 to 10 minutes**, adding flour only as needed. Stand mixer with dough hook, medium speed, **5 to 8 minutes**.
   ✓ *Smooth and supple, no longer shiny*

3. Butter a large bowl, set the dough in it as a ball and cover with plastic wrap. Leave in a warm spot; how long it takes depends on the room.
   WAIT **1 1/2 TO 2 1/2 HR**
   ✓ *Doubled in size*

Filling & assembly

4. Toss the chocolate, brown sugar, cinnamon and pinch of salt together in a small bowl.

5. Divide the dough into 3 equal pieces. Roll each into a 12-inch rope, flatten it with the heel of your hand, then roll it out to a 12 x 6-inch rectangle. It shouldn't need flour.

6. Brush each rectangle with melted butter and scatter a third of the filling over it, leaving a 1/2-inch bare strip along one long edge. That bare strip is what seals the log.

7. Starting from the long side opposite the bare strip, roll each rectangle into a spiral log. Pinch the seam firmly along its length; a log that opens during braiding loses its swirl.

8. Lay the logs seam side down, side by side, on the lined sheet. Pinch together at one end, braid, pinch the far end and tuck both ends under. Keep the braid a little slack, since tension splits the strands in the oven (only cosmetic if it happens). Cover loosely with plastic and set somewhere warm.
   WAIT **1 TO 2 HR**
   ✓ *About 1 1/2 times its original size*

Bake

9. During the second rise, set a rack in the center of the oven and heat it to **350F (175C)**.

10. Brush the loaf all over with beaten egg and sprinkle generously with demerara.
    WAIT **35 TO 45 MIN**
    ✓ *Surface deeply browned*

11. Cool completely on a wire rack before slicing. The filling needs time to set, and a warm loaf tears.

NOTES

Make ahead & storage

- Keeps up to **4 days** at room temperature, well wrapped. Best on day 1 or 2.

Substitutions

- Morton kosher salt is denser than Diamond Crystal: use about 1/2 tsp in the dough.

Pairs with

- Chocolate Pavlova (uses the leftover whites)

My notes

- For 2 loaves, double every ingredient.

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SWEET
CHOCOLATE · SPICED · USES EGG YOLKS · MAKE-AHEAD

Adapted from Dessert Person by Claire Saffitz, p. 235. Method rewritten and condensed for personal kitchen use.